


*will be about the youth").*

A stellar panel, assembled to discuss the state's industrial growth, kickstarted the conclave. Two key voices from the government—Pratap Keshari Deb, minister of energy, industries, micro, small and medium enterprises, and Hemant Sharma, principal secretary of the industries department—were joined by Anil Kumar Singh, president, JSW Steel, Sambalpur-Raigarh-Paradeep plants; Subhrakant Panda, MD, Indian Metals and Ferro Alloys Ltd and immediate past-president, FICCI; Aditya Dash, managing director, The Suryo Group. The debate explored Odisha's inclusive industrialisation approach, the industrial policy of 2022 and how the private sector has partnered with the government to take the mission forward.

This session was followed by an enriching discussion on skill development. Usha Padhee, principal secretary, skill development and technical education department, and Prof. Pradipta Nanda, vice-chancellor, Siksha O Anusandhan Deemed to be University, Bhubaneswar, offered an insightful peek into the steps the government has been taking to skill the state's workforce.

Speaking of Odisha's growth, the spotlight turned on the exemplary universal healthcare system that the government has set up. The session titled 'Health Care: The Odisha Model' threw light on the Biju Swasthya Kalyan Yojana (BSKY), which offers free healthcare to about 80 per cent of the state's population. Dr Bishnu Prasad Mohapatra, additional director of the State Health Assurance Society, which implements BSKY, highlighted the features of the scheme. He was joined by Dr Pusparaj Samantasinghar, medical superintendent, the Institute of Medical Sciences and SUM Hospital, and Kislay Anand, hospital chief operating officer, Care Hospitals.

Education is another area where Odisha has shown innovation, creating an inclusive atmosphere for the large tribal populace. The mother tongue-based Multi-Lingual Education (MLE) programme has been running for more than a decade now at the Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalaya, which provides hostel facilities to dropout girls, bringing gender parity in the state's interiors. While Anupam Saha, state project director, Odisha School Educational Programme Authority, and Indramani Tripathy, director, ST, and additional secretary, ST&SC development department, explained what the administration has done, Panchami Manoo Ukil, vice chairperson, The DN Wisdom Tree Global School, was the voice of the private sector during the discussion.

Odisha's fabled emergence as the sports capital of India is no longer a new story. To discuss it in detail and give an insight into the state's plans, Tusharkanti Behera, minister of state for sports and youth services (independent charge); Srabani Nanda, athlete; and David John, director, Hockey Odisha, took part in the session called 'Odisha: The New Hub of Indian Sports'.

Dr Omkar Rai, executive chairman, Startup Odisha; Priyadarshi Mohapatra, founder and CEO, Curebay; Devesh Sinha, founding member, Bhubaneswar Angels; and Akanksha Priyadarshini, founder and CEO, Aurassure, held an enlightening discussion at the session, 'Start-ups: The Odisha Advantage.'

Then came an interesting rendezvous with two exemplary women—Bishnupriya Das from Mayurbhanj and Raimati Ghiuria from Koraput. Both are part of a seven million-strong network of women who have benefitted from the department of Mission Shakti led by its commissioner-cum-secretary Sujata R. Karthikeyan. While Das manages 450,000 women, Ghiuria—known as the 'millet queen' in Koraput—has conserved 72 traditional native varieties of rice and 30 varieties of millets. Sujata, Das and Ghiuria participated in an extraordinary session, 'Mission Shakti: Empowering Women'.

When it came to culture, Guru Aruna Mohanty, dancer, choreographer and secretary, Orissa Dance Academy, and *MasterChef India* winner Abinas Nayak spoke on the many ways the government and Odia individuals are striving for the preservation and resurgence of their culture, spirituality and heritage. ■

***Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik delivered the keynote address at the INDIA TODAY State of the State Conclave Odisha 2024. Edited excerpts***

It gives me immense pleasure that today we are discussing about our remarkable transformation, not despair, and celebrating success in multiple fields, not dwelling on the pains of the past.

Many devastating natural disasters tested our resilience, but through timely preparedness and swift action, we emerged stronger. From a state of helplessness and despondency in the face of the vagaries of nature, we stood stronger and showed the world how to save lives.

Saving lives was our guiding principle during Covid too. Apart from saving lives across Odisha, we supplied oxygen to various states, saving lives across the country.

In Odisha, we have witnessed remarkable transformation across every sphere. From almost zero investment two decades ago, we have emerged as a favourite destination for investment.

Apart from emerging as a prime destination for manufacturing, we are attracting investments in several frontier technologies, including semiconductors. Today, Odisha is the aluminium capital of South Asia and the steel hub of India.

Two decades ago, when I assumed charge, Odisha was in a severe financial mess. Now, we are known across the country for our excellence in fiscal management.

Two decades ago, Odisha evoked the picture of abject poverty and malnutrition. KBK (Kalahandi Balangir Koraput) region was glamourised in me-